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COVER STORY

THE NEW CMs

BETTING ON FRESH FACES

THE BJP USHERS IN A GENERATIONAL SHIFT IN THREE STATES AS THE CONGRESS DOES IN TELANGANA, TO GROOM THE LEADERSHIP OF THE FUTURE

By **AMARNATH K. MENON & ANILESH S. MAHAJAN**

Political parties are in the throes of a defining moment, at least in anointing chief ministers of states that have elected new legislative assemblies, even as the parliamentary polls loom large. The BJP has taken the lead in introducing generational change by picking three men, all in their 50s, exemplifying diversity. A first-time MLA, the 56-year-old Bhajan Lal Sharma is a Brahmin and the new chief minister of Rajasthan. An equally surprising pick is four-time chief minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan's replacement in Madhya Pradesh—the 58-year-old Mohan Yadav, an OBC. Earlier, in Chhattisgarh, the saffron party installed another new face—that of 59-year-old Vishnu Deo Sai, who belongs to the Scheduled Tribes.

These changes, marking a tectonic shift in the political landscape, unfolded over three days, a week after results in three northern states announced the season of saffron. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and